

Infecting germs

Many infectious diseases are caused by microscopic living organisms. They live and multiply inside our bodies and can pass from human to human by touch, through blood or saliva, and through the air.



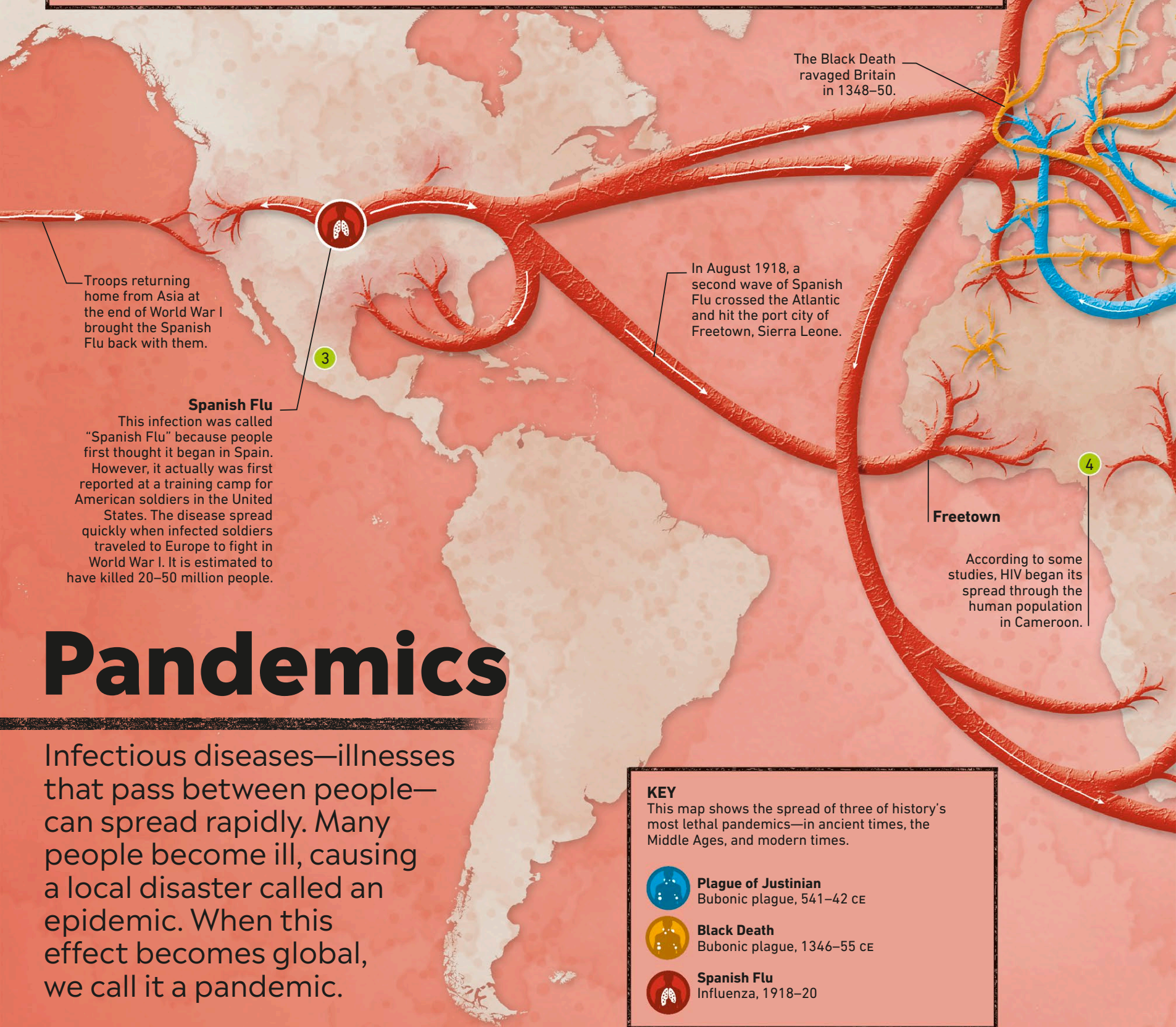
Bubonic plague bacteria

Bacteria are single-celled organisms that multiply by dividing into two again and again. Millions could fit on the head of a pin. Today, many bacterial infections can be treated with antibiotics.



Flu virus

Viruses are very simple organisms far smaller even than bacteria. They spread by invading and taking over cells in the body. Viruses are unharmed by antibiotics, but the body can be fortified against them with a vaccine.



Pandemics

Infectious diseases—illnesses that pass between people—can spread rapidly. Many people become ill, causing a local disaster called an epidemic. When this effect becomes global, we call it a pandemic.